among the vegetable sources it is green leafy vegetables. Among the green leafy vegetables, amaranth, fenugreek and drumstick leaves are rich sources of calcium. Ragi among cereals is a rich source of calcium. Small dried fish, nuts and oil seeds like gingelly seeds, betel leaf with slaked lime are also a rich source.

- **Absorption:**

  Factors increasing absorption of calcium: Vitamin D, acidity of digestive mass, lactose, protein and phosphorus are the factors which favor the absorption of calcium.

  Factors decreasing absorption of calcium: Oxalic acid, phytic acid, high fat diets including steatorrhea, emotional instability, increased gastrointestinal mobility, lack of exercise, ageing, caffeine and drugs decrease the absorption of calcium in the body.

Food for thought: Cola beverages and bone fractures

Drinking cola beverages which contain phosphoric acid and often caffeine may increase the fragility of bones in children and adolescents. So it's better to avoid cola drinks.

- **Health Problems/ Deficiency:**
  - **Osteoporosis:** This is a condition associated with a loss in bone density and bone mass which literally means "porous bone". With the ageing process resorption predominates bone formation resulting in osteoporosis.

    Risk factors for osteoporosis include
    - Females who are fair complexioned are at eight times more at risk
    - Asian Race
    - Family history
    - Prolonged dietary insufficiency
    - Poor absorption and utilization of calcium
    - Restricted movement
    - Decreased levels of estrogen
    - Hyper parathyroidism
    - Vitamin D insufficiency
  - **Osteomalacia:** It is a condition where the quality of the bone is diminished and the quantity of the bone is not compromised.
  - **Osteopenia:** It refers to the bone density that is lower than normal peak density but not low enough to be classified as osteoporosis.

The strength of the bone is measured by a bone density test using a CT (Computed Tomography) scan or DEXA (Dual energy X ray Absorptiometry). The numerical result of the bone density is quantified as a "T score". The lower the T score, the lower the bone density. T scores greater than 1.0 are considered normal and indicate healthy bone. T scores between 1.0 and -2.5 indicate osteopenia. T scores lower than -2.5 indicate osteoporosis.

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